

# Syllabus

## PS50008A Research Methods & Experimental Design | Term 2 Spring 2026

Gordon Wright

27 May 2026

### Module Information

|                      |                                        |
|----------------------|----------------------------------------|
| <b>Module Code</b>   | PS50008A                               |
| <b>Module Title</b>  | Research Methods & Experimental Design |
| <b>Credits</b>       | 30 (Level 3 / Foundation)              |
| <b>Term</b>          | 2 (Spring 2026)                        |
| <b>Academic Year</b> | 2025-26                                |

### Module Description

This module introduces foundation students to the principles of psychological research. You will learn how to design experiments, collect and analyse data, and report findings in accordance with professional standards.

A distinctive feature of this module is **DataLab**—in Week 11, you generate the dataset you'll analyse throughout the term. This means you learn statistics using your own data, not abstract examples.

### Learning Outcomes

On successful completion of this module, you will be able to:

#### Conceptual Understanding (C)

- Identify experimental designs (between-participants, within-participants, matched pairs, correlational)
- Distinguish between IVs and DVs
- Formulate appropriate hypotheses (one-tailed, two-tailed)
- Understand null hypothesis significance testing
- Select appropriate statistical tests
- Interpret p-values, confidence intervals, and effect sizes

- Recognise the difference between correlation and causation
- Critically evaluate research claims

### Practical Skills (P)

- Calculate descriptive statistics by hand
- Run t-tests and correlations in R
- Produce appropriate data visualisations
- Check statistical assumptions
- Report results in APA format

### Research Skills (R)

- Develop research questions
- Operationalise variables
- Design appropriate methodologies
- Collect data systematically
- Write research reports
- Critique methodological approaches
- Consider ecological validity

## Teaching Schedule

| Session     | Day       | Time        | Location |
|-------------|-----------|-------------|----------|
| Lecture     | Wednesday | 10:00-12:00 | RHBD 143 |
| Lab Group A | Thursday  | 10:00-12:00 | WB 304a  |
| Lab Group B | Thursday  | 10:00-12:00 | WB 304b  |

### Week 11

There is no lecture in Week 11. Read the intro lecture reading and attend your lab session on Thursday for DataLab.

## Weekly Materials

Each week typically includes:

| Material        | Description                       |
|-----------------|-----------------------------------|
| Lecture Slides  | Core content (RevealJS, recorded) |
| Lecture Reading | Textbook content for the week     |
| Lab Slides      | Introduction to lab session       |
| Lab Activity    | Interactive WebR exercises        |

| Material         | Description                    |
|------------------|--------------------------------|
| Lab Reading      | Supporting practical material  |
| Self-Assessments | Weekly consolidation exercises |

## Assessment

See the Assessments page for full details.

| Assessment      | Weight | Deadline        |
|-----------------|--------|-----------------|
| Research Plan   | 20%    | Fri 27 Feb 2026 |
| MCQ Exam        | 20%    | Wed 11 Mar 2026 |
| EDS Assignment  | 20%    | Fri 20 Mar 2026 |
| Research Report | 40%    | 1 May 2026      |

## Required Reading

### Recommended Textbooks

Although I have tried to provide detailed readings here, so that you don't have to lean on textbooks, sometimes a new voice is handy to help grapple with a new topic. Both textbooks below are great and are available as e-books via the Goldsmiths Library:

- **Coolican, H. (2017). *Research methods and statistics in psychology* (6th Ed.).** Hodder and Stoughton. VLeBooks
- **Harris, P. (2008). *Designing and reporting experiments in psychology* (3rd Ed.).** Open University Press. VLeBooks

Weekly readings are specified on each week's page. See the Resources page for additional materials.

## Software

We will talk about this in detail before any use of software is required!

| Software | Purpose                | Access                                       |
|----------|------------------------|----------------------------------------------|
| R        | Statistical analysis   | Free download or use the Goldsmiths R Server |
| WebR     | In-browser R exercises | Built into course materials                  |

You do not need to install R to complete this module—all lab activities use WebR, which runs in your browser, and there will be extremely helpful guides and examples.

## Group Project

Working in groups is a core part of this module. Later in the term, your group (comprising 3-4 students) will design and run your own study, collect real data, and write it up as a research report. The group project is a substantial part of your assessment, and the quality of your collaboration directly affects your experience and your grade.

### Forming Your Groups

In Week 11, you will work in small groups (2-4 students). This matters, so we are having a nice gentle start!

Pay attention to who communicates clearly, who seems enthusiastic, who you can rely on. Consider working with people you feel comfortable working with outside class hours. Your group will work together on labs from Week 16 onwards and on the research project which makes up a large part of this module. It doesn't mean that you can't start planning your group members and group working strategy now though!

#### ! Choose Wisely

Group formation is your first opportunity to see how groups naturally assemble and how different people work together. Group work is a VERY psychological phenomenon and the thing we are asked to talk about most often when writing references for jobs or further study.

### Project Timeline

| Week  | Skills & Procedures                                | Communication          |
|-------|----------------------------------------------------|------------------------|
| 11    | Grow your own data (DataLab)                       | —                      |
| 12-15 | Develop research skills and design knowledge       | Reporting Psychology   |
| —     | <i>Reading Week</i>                                | —                      |
| 16-17 | Form groups, choose topic, draft project documents | Methods & Introduction |
| 18    | Finalise materials, practice run                   | Procedure & Materials  |
| 19    | Data collection                                    | Results                |
| 20    | Gordon returns analysed data                       | Discussion & Report    |

### Assessments from Group Work

The project feeds into two assessments:

- **Research Plan** (due Week 16) — A methods section on a given topic (individual)
- **Research Report** (due 1 May 2026) — Individual write-up of group data (individual)

While the data collection is collaborative, both the Research Plan and Research Report are individual submissions. You are responsible for your own work and your own academic integrity.

#### Labs in Project Groups

From Week 16 onwards, labs require you to work in your project groups.

## Attendance Policy

Attendance at all lectures and labs is expected and required. This module builds cumulatively—missing sessions will affect your understanding of later material.

- **Attendance** is recorded via SEATS in both lectures and labs
- **Preparation** and independent study are expected each week
- **Readings** should be completed as specified

#### DataLab

Attendance at Week 11 was essential for DataLab participation. This generated the dataset used throughout the term. Your own data forms the basis of all lab activities and analyses.

## Academic Integrity

All submitted work must be your own. The group project requires collaboration, but the Research Plan and Research Report are individual submissions.

Using AI tools to generate your work is not permitted. You may use AI to help understand concepts, but submitted work must be your own.

## Support

| Resource     | Details                                                      |
|--------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| Office Hours | Thursday 12:00 - 13:00                                       |
| Email        | <a href="mailto:g.wright@gold.ac.uk">g.wright@gold.ac.uk</a> |
| VLE          | Discussion board for general questions                       |

## Additional Resources

- Resources Page
- Goldsmiths Library
- Academic Skills Centre